

Backyard Fence Line Landscape Plan

Karl Foerster Grass + Pollinator Perennial Border

Design Plan

May 2026

Backyard Fence Line Landscape Plan

A modern, low-maintenance perennial border along ~46 linear feet of stepped fence line. Two-layer planting: upright ornamental grasses behind, repeating pollinator perennial in front. Designed for clay-over-rock soil (Evanston / North Shore IL, USDA Zone 5b-6a).

1. Site Summary

Location: Wilmette / Evanston, IL — USDA Zone 5b-6a **Light:** Read as part sun based on photos (tree canopy on right end, open sky on left/middle). Assume **4-6 hrs direct sun**. Both proposed flowers and Karl Foerster tolerate this. **Soil:** Workable topsoil 4-10" deep, buried rock/rubble below. **No tilling possible.** **Fence:** Stepped wood privacy fence with lattice top. Three runs:

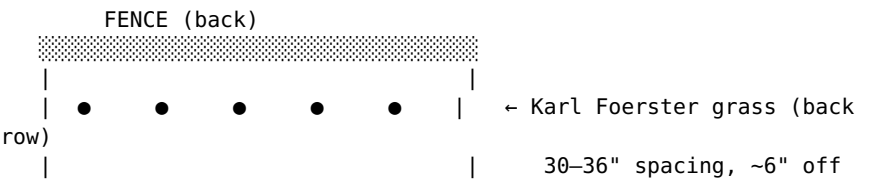
Section	Length	Depth (bed)
Left	168"	30-33"
Middle (inset)	153"	30-33"
Right	228"	30-33"
Total	~549" / 45.75 ft	

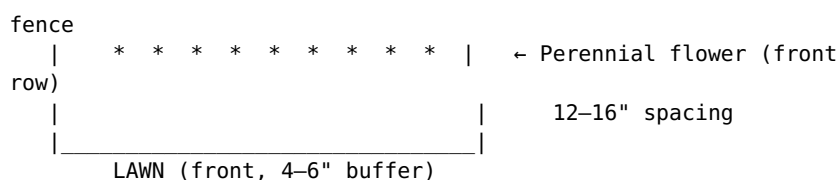
Existing obstacles to plan around:

- Mature tree at right end (visible in photos) — roots will compete. Pull last 2-3 grasses 24-36" away from trunk and substitute drought-tolerant filler if needed.
- Climbing dome on lawn side — bed edge must stay clear by ~12" minimum.
- Solar lights mounted on fence posts — preserve clearance for fixtures.

2. Design Concept

Two-layer linear border.





Why this works:

- **Vertical contrast:** 4-5 ft upright grass plumes against horizontal fence boards
- **Seasonal interest:** Grass goes green→gold→tan (April-March). Flowers cover June-September.
- **Repetition over variety:** Only two species along 46 ft. Reads as intentional design, not a “collector’s garden.”
- **Pollinator value:** Both flower options are native or native-adjacent and support bees + butterflies.

3. Plant Selection

Back row (structure) — locked in

Karl Foerster Feather Reed Grass (*Calamagrostis x acutiflora* ‘Karl Foerster’)

- Height: 4-5 ft in bloom; 2.5-3 ft foliage
- Spread: 18-24"
- Sun: Full sun to part sun (tolerates 4 hrs)
- Bloom: Pinkish plumes in June, fading to wheat-tan all winter
- Sterile cultivar — does **not** self-seed or become invasive
- Cold-hardy to Zone 4; rock-solid in Zone 5b
- Standard #1 (1-gallon) pot at nursery

Front row (color) — choose one at purchase

I’m presenting both so you can decide at the nursery based on what looks healthiest. Both work with Karl Foerster.

Option A — Coneflower (*Echinacea purpurea*)

Trait	Detail
Height	2.5-4 ft
Bloom	Late June - September, pink-purple daisy
Sun	4+ hrs (your conditions OK)
Drought tolerance	High once established
Best feature	Strong upright stems, seedheads feed goldfinches into winter
Recommended cultivars	Straight species <i>E. purpurea</i> , ‘Magnus’ (more uniform), ‘PowWow Wild Berry’ (compact)
Avoid	Double-flowered or wild-colored hybrids (orange/yellow) — short-lived, less hardy

Option B — Black-eyed Susan (*Rudbeckia*)

Trait	Detail
Height	2-3 ft

Bloom	Mid-July - October, gold-yellow daisy with dark center
Sun	4+ hrs
Drought tolerance	High once established
Best feature	Longer bloom window than coneflower; brighter color contrast with grass
Recommended cultivar	<i>Rudbeckia fulgida</i> 'Goldsturm' — true perennial, NOT <i>R. hirta</i> which is biennial
Avoid	<i>Rudbeckia hirta</i> sold as annual color — won't reliably return

△ **Plan correction:** The original plan listed *Rudbeckia hirta*. That's a short-lived biennial/annual. For a permanent border, buy '**Goldsturm**' instead.

Decision rule

- Want **height + structure + winter seedheads** → Coneflower
- Want **longer bloom + brighter yellow + uniform 24" mass** → Goldsturm
- Both are fine, just don't mix in this length — one species reads cleaner.

4. Spacing & Counts

Back row — Karl Foerster

Centers placed **6" off fence**, spaced **32" apart** (midpoint of 30-36" range).

Section	Length	# of Grasses	Spacing notes
Left (168")	168"	5	16" margin each end, 32" centers
Middle (153")	153"	5	12.5" margin each end, 32" centers
Right (228")	228"	7	18" margin each end, 32" centers (last grass moved 24"+ from tree trunk)
Total		17	

Front row — perennial flower

Centers placed **8" from front edge** of bed (lawn side), spaced **14" apart**.

Section	Length	# of Flowers
Left (168")	168"	11
Middle (153")	153"	10
Right (228")	228"	15

Total	36
--------------	-----------

Buy list (with 10% buffer for losses)

Plant	Calculated	Buy
Karl Foerster grass (#1 / 1-gal)	17	18-19
Coneflower OR Goldsturm (#1 quart or 1-gal)	36	40

5. Buying Guide

Where to buy (Chicago North Shore)

1. **Chalet Nursery (Wilmette)** — closest, best plant quality, premium pricing
2. **Pesche's Flowers / Garden Center (Des Plaines)** — good native selection
3. **Gethsemane Garden Center (Andersonville)** — strong perennial selection
4. **Possibility Place Nursery (Monee)** — natives specialist, worth the drive for bulk
5. **Big-box (Home Depot / Lowes)** — only as last resort; grass is usually fine, perennials are hit-or-miss

What to look for

Karl Foerster grass: - ✓ Multiple stiff green blades emerging from crown - ✓ Roots fill the pot but aren't a tight white spiral - ✓ No yellowing or brown bases - ✗ Avoid pots where soil pulls away from the edge — drought-stressed

Coneflower / Goldsturm: - ✓ Multiple stems from base (not a single stem — that's a young plug) - ✓ Dark green foliage, no leaf spot or yellowing - ✓ A few buds OK, full bloom not necessary (plants in heavy bloom transplant worse) - ✗ Avoid plants flopping or with mushy crowns

Materials checklist

Item	Qty	Notes
Karl Foerster grass	18-19	#1 pot
Flower (Coneflower OR Goldsturm)	40	quart or #1 pot
Compost / planting mix	~6 cu ft	One bag per ~10 holes
Shredded hardwood mulch	~2 cu yd	Or 12-14 bags of 2 cu ft
Landscape edging (optional)	46 lin ft	Steel or composite, NOT plastic roll
Soil knife / hori-hori	1	Worth the \$25
Round-point shovel	1	
Digging bar / rock bar	1	For prying buried rocks — essential here
Bucket(s) for excavated rock	2-3	
Mason's line +		For marking front

stakes	1 set	edge
Marking flags or spray paint	1 pack	To mark plant centers
Slow-release fertilizer (e.g. Plant-tone)	1 bag	Optional, light handful per hole
Watering can or hose w/ shower wand	1	

Estimated cost: \$450-\$700 total depending on nursery and whether you buy edging.

6. Installation Sequence

Day 0 — Prep (afternoon, 1-2 hrs)

1. Mark the **front bed edge** with mason's line stretched between stakes. Step back and check the line from the house. Adjust until it looks straight from the viewing angle that matters.
2. Cut the edge with a flat spade — clean vertical cut, ~4" deep.
3. Pull sod inside the bed. Compost it or flip it grass-down in the hole.
4. Hand-weed any remaining roots.

Day 1 — Layout (morning, 30 min)

5. Use a tape measure + flags to mark **grass centers** (32" apart, 6" off fence).
6. Then mark **flower centers** in a staggered line 8" off the front edge, 14" apart.
7. Walk the bed. Sight down the row. Adjust flags before digging.

Day 1 — Dig & plant grasses (2-3 hrs)

8. For each grass position: dig a hole 14" wide × 10" deep. **Stop and pry out rocks** with the digging bar as you hit them. Set rocks aside (don't refill with them).
9. Mix excavated soil 50/50 with compost in a bucket.
10. Set grass at same depth as nursery pot — **crown level with grade, never buried.**
11. Backfill, firm gently with hands (don't stomp), water in immediately.

Day 1 or 2 — Plant flowers (1-2 hrs)

12. Dig 8" × 8" holes for each flower. Same rock-removal process.
13. Mix soil + compost, plant at original depth, water in.

Day 2 — Mulch & water

14. Spread **2-3" of shredded hardwood mulch** across the whole bed. Pull mulch back ~2" from the base of each plant — don't volcano-mulch.
 15. Deep-water the entire bed. Plan to water 2-3× per week for the first 4 weeks, then taper.
-

7. Soil & Rock Strategy (your specific situation)

The buried rock layer is the single biggest risk to this install. **Do not till.** Tilling drags rocks up and breaks your blades.

Per-hole protocol: 1. Dig with shovel until you hit resistance. 2. Switch to digging bar — pry, don't lever against rock fragments. 3. Once a rock is loose, lift it out. Set it in a bucket. 4. If you hit a rock you cannot remove in ~3 minutes, **shift the plant position 6-8" left or right.** Mark the new spot. The eye will not detect that small adjustment. 5. Never plant on top of a flat rock — water will pool and rot the crown.

What to do with excavated rock: Stockpile it. It's free drainage material for the bottom of future holes elsewhere, or fill for low spots along the fence base.

8. First-Year Care Calendar

Month	Task
Plant week	Water deeply every 2-3 days for 2 weeks
Weeks 3-8	Water 1-2× weekly, deep soaking
Aug-Sep	Taper watering. Pull any weeds before they set seed.
Oct-Nov	Leave grass and flower stalks standing — winter interest + bird food. Do NOT cut back.
March (yr 2)	Cut Karl Foerster to 4-6" with hedge shears or hand pruners BEFORE new growth emerges. Cut flower stalks at the same time.
April (yr 2)	Light handful of slow-release fertilizer per plant. Refresh mulch to 2".
June (yr 2)	Bed should look fully filled in. Grass plumes emerge.

9. Gotchas & Common Mistakes

1. **Planting too deep.** The #1 killer of perennials. Crown stays AT grade, not buried.
2. **Mulch volcano against the grass crown.** Causes rot. Keep mulch 2" away from base.
3. **Cutting Karl Foerster in fall.** It looks great all winter — wheat-colored plumes against snow. Cut in March, not November.
4. **Watering shallow + frequent.** Trains roots to stay near the surface. Water DEEP, less often.
5. **Planting the Echinacea cultivar 'Cheyenne Spirit' or other hybrids.** Pretty for one season, then dead. Stick with straight species or 'Magnus' / 'PowWow Wild Berry'.
6. **Buying *Rudbeckia hirta* instead of *R. fulgida* 'Goldsturm'.** *Hirta* is biennial and will not be a permanent border.
7. **Crowding the tree.** The mature tree on the right will out-compete plants within ~24" of its drip line. Leave a small gap; don't fight it.

8. **Plastic landscape edging (the rolled black stuff).** Heaves out of the ground in 2 winters. Use steel, composite, or no edging.
 9. **Skipping mulch to “save money.”** Year 1 mulch is non-negotiable for soil moisture and weed suppression.
-

10. Year 2-3 Look

By summer of year 2 you'll see:

- Karl Foerster: full 4-5 ft plumes by late June, holding through winter
- Flowers: dense 24-30" cushion of bloom from late June through September
- The bed reads as a **continuous green-and-gold (or green-and-purple) ribbon** along the entire fence line

By year 3 the grasses may need division (every 3-4 years). Lift in early spring, split with a sharp spade, replant or share.

11. Quick-Reference Summary

- **17 grasses + 36 flowers** (buy 18-19 + 40)
- **Karl Foerster** behind, **Echinacea OR Goldsturm Rudbeckia** in front
- Grass 32" apart, 6" off fence
- Flowers 14" apart, 8" off front edge
- Dig individual holes, remove rocks, **never till**
- Mulch 2-3" hardwood, leave 2" gap around crowns
- Don't cut back until March